



Garmin Nuvi 350

ed GPS system like the ones from MapmyIndia and Satguide.

The device is small and compact like the MapmyIndia A-MAX 06GP5A. The advantage of using products this small is that you have the option of carrying it around in your pant pocket or pouch when you step out of your vehicle or go on an off-track outdoor trip. The screen quality is also very identical to the A-MAX 06GP5A. The Nuvi 350 is one of the few devices to come with a foldable antenna. There's also provision for an extendible antenna for better performance.

When you first power it on, the welcome menu lets you down with an underwhelming three-option menu. It's only later that you discover that the software interface on the Garmin is actually made to be clean and organized. There is use of sober colours all throughout the software. Even the maps follow a similar theme. This combination is truly unique and will suit many users. When day turns to night, the Nuvi 350 can be set to switch a night mode which changes the colour scheme to be more of a contrasted darker interface. There is a very simple menu to look for places of interests such as dining places, fuel stations and so on. The artwork used for the selection is very nice done. While going through its entire feature set, the great performance of the interface is easy to notice.

The trip computer is simpler looking but it has all current live information updated on it. It gives you information about the moving time, the time you've stopped, your average speed and so on. This device is all about the function and less about the presentation and style.

The Garmin Nuvi 350 even has an optional addon for the traffic receiver. The software interface has an option which

can be enabled only if you have this module. The feature lets you know of traffic reports and information on it on the Nuvi 350. Unfortunately, this unique little feature is subscription based and more importantly not available in India at the moment.

If you're looking for some kind of entertainment from your GPS system, then the Nuvi 350 will in no way disappoint. There is a media player for music playback, an image viewer and even an audiobook reader - all the things that your passengers will find interesting. The nifty bit of software is the language translator that gives voice results in different languages. You can then travel to other countries and still be able to have basic communication with the people of the region. There is also a cur-

rency calculator, a measurement convertor and even a world clock that keeps track of time in different places.

Garmin's experience in GPS devices is clearly visible in the case of the Nuvi 350. This is one of the best GPS devices we've seen. At Rs 27,300 without taxes, it also happens to be the costliest one. Although the higher price is hard to justify, it's a great buy for those without budgets.

Satguide Mio C230

The Mio C230 is supplied and distributed by Satguide under their branding here in India - with their software and maps of course. The Mio C230 has a decent 3.5-inch screen that operates at a resolution of 320 x 240. The screen is more or less the typical size of Windows Mobile phones and PDAs. It's a compact device with lots of rounded edges. Again, this is another device that can be carried away with you when you leave the car.

The touch screen is both accurate and functions well with the interface. The performance of the C230 isn't as good as the Nuvi. There is some amount of delay while operating the device and while loading maps of different regions when you scroll. We also had some stability issues when we accessed some features. The application would randomly crash and the device had to be restarted. This could have been an issue with the device we received.

The maps are detailed but this can get crowded, especially when you zoom out a bit. The maps even have names of many buildings and this part of the reason why the interface can be so flooded with information. Operating the software is simple and straight-forward. The only thing that bothers us is the colours and look of the interface. Although simple, it's doesn't look as smooth or refined when compared to the other interface on the

Satguide Mio C230



other devices. The windshield mounting mechanism is really sturdy and works very well. It is also flexible with its joints and allows you to mount the unit in a variety of ways.

The PMP feature of the device is really impressive. The player has a proper playlist and even seeking features. The speaker is also pretty good so as a whole, for music playback this is a very good device to own. Even though it's not the perfect GPS, it is incredibly cheap in comparison to the other devices of its kind. The price of Rs 16,000 is truly impressive and makes the device a very good value-for-money purchase.

Satguide Mio P360

When you first look at the Satguide Mio P360, it looks like a slightly oversized PDA or a touch screen phone with a 3.5-inch screen. The external looks are quite impressive as well. It's also built very well. You could call this a handheld GPS device but you might find it difficult to fit into your shirt pocket very easily. The device runs Windows Mobile 6 and like any other PDA boots up into the operating system.

It comes installed with the Satguide application which needs to be run by going into the Programs menu on the device. The application that loads is identical to the one used on the other device we received from Satguide - the Mio C230. In comparison, the same software runs really horribly on the P360. It has none of the crashing issues but it performs really poorly. The device by itself runs rather well and even better than some of the other phones and PDAs we've used.

The software, like on the C230, isn't the nicest looking one. The interface is simple but colours used are too gaudy. The touch screen is not as sensitive and controlling the device is quite troublesome. The maps and the rest of the software are exactly the same as the C230.



Satguide Mio P360

The speaker on the P360 is exceptionally good. It is loud and crystal clear. It comes with a 2.5mm jack which means you will need some kind of a convertor to connect conventional earphones to it. A connector for an external antenna is also available.

Even though we aren't impressed by the P360 for its GPS features, you must remember that you get a good fully functional PDA for the money you spend on it. You can run any Windows Mobile application on it. At that, it will undoubtedly excel. The price for the P360 is Rs 19,490 which is still asking a lot in our opinion. For those who want just the GPS functionality, the Mio C230 is the better of the two Mio devices.

GPS Bluetooth Receivers

One of the cheapest and simplest ways to use a GPS is with your phone, PDA or laptop. All you need then is what is commonly referred to as a GPS receiver. These are cheaper than dedicated GPS units and the choice of software that you want to use with it is left to you. Along with the completely ready GPS units, we received three GPS receivers and we had to give him a run to see how they ran. Most of the GPS receivers you get today con-



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